

By Malini Bhupta and Swati Mathur |

A German army commander once famously said of the British Army that it was a bunch of "lions led by donkeys". The reference was to the soldiers who were led to their deaths by inept generals during the First World War. In Mumbai, a similar tragedy was unveiled on November 26, as the top brass of Mumbai Police took the backseat in the comfort of their luxury cars while their brave footsoldiers fell to terrorists' bullets.

The mandatory back-patting and self-congratulations over, the Mumbai Police top brass is now faced with uncomfortable questions about the quality of their leadership. In response to opposition leader Ramdas Kadam's charges against Commissioner of Police Hasan Gafoor and Director-General (DG) of Police A.N. Roy, all that Chief Minister Ashok Chavan would commit last week was a high-level probe into the alleged lapses, an indication of the confusion at the top political levels. The announcement was made after the Shiv Sena and the BJP demanded removal of Roy and Gafoor, along with Home Secretary



Force DIVIDER

Investigations into the Mumbai attacks are likely to be hampered by the rift in the police top brass and the politicisation of the force

Chitkala Zutshi. The three have been squarely blamed for the alleged lapses. Despite the pointed fingers, the Mumbai Police is a divided house. One would expect that this crisis would have come as a wake-up call for the police force and their political masters, but the intense infighting and one-upmanship indicates that any kind of change is a long way off.

Be it Gafoor's refusal to cooperate with the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) team, which was left hanging for three days, or keeping the Anti-Terror Squad (ATS) out of investigations, or even leaking their "heroic footage" during operations, the Mumbai Police has left no stone unturned in bungling. All attempts to reach the commissioner and the DG failed as they refused to take calls or respond to faxes.

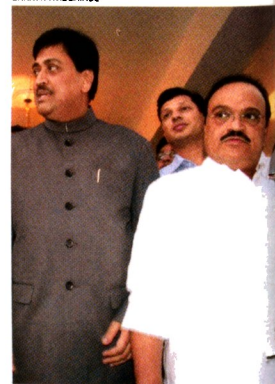
Senior officers attribute the leadership crisis to the politicisation of the force and the rift between the DG and the commissioner, which

intensified during Roy's tenure as commissioner of Mumbai. This battle is now beginning to impact the investigations with the ATS probing only the CSR attacks.

Since its inception in July 2004, all terror attacks in the state, except 26/11, have been investigated by this special squad. However, since the squad comes under the DG, it's getting a raw deal. Says former DGP of Maharashtra Arvind Inamdar, "Ideally, the investigations should have been given to the ATS. However, since 2000, the Mumbai commissioner of Police started reporting to the home minister and home secretary instead of the DG. This goes against the concept of one force and one leader." Strangely, sources in the Home Ministry justify the decision by saying that the squad is "less capable" than the Crime Branch.

The constant tussle between the ATS and the Crime Branch may be legion, but it is one

SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE



That the chief minister and his deputy are from different parties adds to the problems